BOOKS ▼

Colonial Frostbite

DEEPA ANAPPARA's latest novel is a monumental adventure set in 19th-century India and Tibet

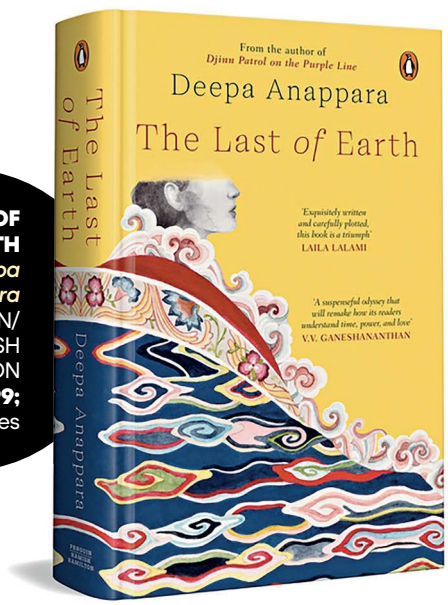
The premise of *The Last of Earth* is that the local guides who accompanied British adventurers into the Himalaya must have been formidable mountaineers and adventurers themselves. Set in the second half of the 19th century, the hero of this richly detailed novel is Balram, a one-time schoolteacher. He and his childhood friend Gyan have been trained as surveyor-spies for the British Indian Empire. Their primary value to the empire is that, unlike white-skinned foreigners, they can pass into the Forbidden Kingdom of Tibet.

Alas for Balram, an Englishman is determined to lead the mission. Disguised as a saffron-clad holy man and known only as "the captain", this ill-tempered man is the stereotypical colonial for whom "natives" are barely human. The team of porters who carry equipment and supplies despise the captain while dreading the wrath of guardian deities who protect the sacred mountains from foreign devils. And Gyan, who should have been Balram's partner, went missing while on a previous mission. Three years have passed, and he is presumed dead. But Balram is determined to find out what happened to him.

THE LAST OF EARTH
By Deepa Anappara
PENGUIN/ HAMISH HAMILTON
₹899; 384 pages

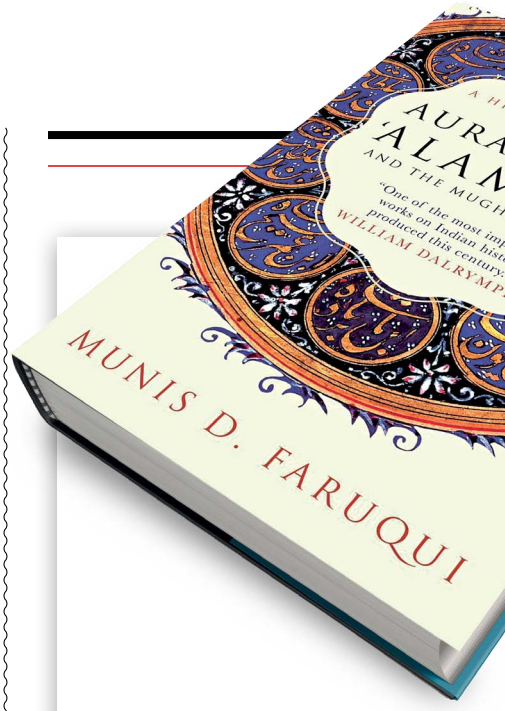
Meanwhile, 50-year-old Katherine, a half-blood English adventuress, is also headed for Lhasa. Why? Because the Empire needs to know that its women are just as indomitable as its men. Instead of a team of porters, she has only Mani, a sweet-natured young man. She calls him her son while treating him like a pack animal. Lastly, there's Chetak, the long-haired, multilingual mystery man who just happens to be lurking about the high Himalaya. In his cool, all-knowing way, he functions like a handy plot device, turning up whenever he's needed.

The extremes of climate, the forbidding terrain and the physical injuries sustained by all the travellers are convincingly described. So are



Katherine's eccentricities and Balram's yearning to save Gyan. But unlike Deepa Anappara's highly praised debut novel, *Djinn Patrol on the Purple Line*, the characters in this book are hard to like. Fixated on their personal quests, locked into their separate cultural traditions, they become frost-bitten pawns in the author's version of Rudyard Kipling's 'Great Game'. ■

—Manjula Padmanabhan



BOOKS ▼

EMPEROR REVISITED

MUNIS D. FARUQUI CHALLENGES ESTABLISHED STEREOTYPES OF AURANGZEB AND OFFERS A NUANCED REASSESSMENT OF THE MUGHAL EMPEROR

BOOKS ▶

The Show Mu

Vishwas Patil's moving historical novel brings to life a woman's valiant struggle to save her circus, its artistes and animals during World War II

Indian law prohibits the use of wild animals in circuses to protect them from human cruelty and exploitation. But there was a time when Indian circuses were in great demand for acts staged by performing animals. They travelled long distances, across Burma,